



THE LAST ONE

It ended with Rory McIlroy on his knees, overwhelmed by equal parts joy and release. After years of near misses at golf's most exacting stage, the 36-year-old finally conquered Augusta to win the Masters and complete the career Grand Slam. He became only the sixth player in history to do so.

True to form, McIlroy took the longest and most tortuous route. What began as a position of control quickly unravelled. A two-shot lead vanished early. A four-shot cushion on the back nine followed it. A missed five-foot par putt for a one-over 73 forced the first Masters playoff in eight years.

"I started to wonder if it would ever be my time," McIlroy admitted later, as Augusta threatened to reopen old wounds.

This time, though, he steadied himself. A nerveless wedge shot spun back to three feet, applying pressure where it mattered. When Justin Rose failed to convert from 15 feet, McIlroy finally grasped what had eluded him for so long.

The victory ended an 11-year wait for a Major and made him the first Northern Irishman to wear the green jacket. More than the jacket, it was a vindication of stubborn persistence in the face of repeated disappointment.

"It's the best day of my golfing life," McIlroy said. "I'm proud of never giving up. I'm proud of how I kept coming back and not letting the disappointments define me."

In joining Tiger Woods, Jack Nicklaus, Gary Player, Ben Hogan and Gene Sarazen as winners of all four Majors, McIlroy did not just enter history. He rewrote the ending to his own long, unfinished story.